



Go-to circuit-breaker: Rishabh Pant's significance this Test season cannot be overstated, especially with the Test series Down Under looming large and his heroics at the Gabba in 2021-22 still the flavour of the storied rivalry. **K. MURALI KUMAR**

day-four pitch that turned and kept low, Mehidy Hasan Miraz had the visitor in a bind before Shreyas Iyer and R. Ashwin's rearguard led to a scrappy three-wicket win.

Rohit missed that series, but he will keep his unit from drifting into complacency as Bangladesh is no stranger to these conditions.

India and Bangladesh are the most spin-friendly host countries in Tests since 2020, where the tweekers average 25.55 and 32.11 runs per wicket, respectively.

The host will take lessons from its four defeats at home in the last seven years, where rank turners were a double-edged sword, be it against Australia in Pune in 2017 and Indore in 2023, or versus England in 2021 in Chennai.

India's dwindling returns against spin bowling at home were arrested to an extent during the England series this year, and the absence of prodigious turn and uneven bounce meant run-scoring wasn't reduced to a mere lottery. That said, Tom Hartley's seven-for in Hyderabad did jolt the host initially.

India's top six batters' cumulative batting average against spin had dropped to 40 runs per wicket in 2021, and the slide continued in 2022 (36.5) and 2023 (25.9) before rising to 48.4 this year. With the return of Virat Kohli, KL Rahul and Rishabh Pant, India will hope to further allay its spin demons. Kohli missed the five-match series against England due to personal reasons, and with his

batting average against spin on the mend, his experience will be vital in the middle-order against the likes of Miraz and Shakib Al Hasan.

Rahul, meanwhile, freed up of wicketkeeping duties and coming off a half-century in the Duleep Trophy, will have a case to make after missing four out of five Tests this year due to injury. With Sarfaraz Khan breathing down his neck for a spot in the middle-order, his task will be cut out. Similarly, Pant will have to fend off a credible challenge from Dhruv Jurel for the wicketkeeper's role and reassert his indispensability as a left-handed, spin-bashing circuit-breaker.

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WTC Points Table (as of 10-9-2024)

Position	Team	Matches	Won	Lost	Drawn	Points	PCT
1	India	9	6	2	1	74	68.52
2	Australia	12	8	3	1	90	62.53
3	New Zealand	6	3	3	0	36	50.04
4	Bangladesh	6	3	3	0	33	45.83
5	Sri Lanka	7	3	4	0	36	42.86